

God's will

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...Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

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Introduction

We have all heard the Lord's prayer, and many of us know it by heart. One part stands out to many in particular: "...Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven." This is a prayer we pray, following Christ's model prayer, and it has become a popular tagline in many churches.

What does it mean?

What does it mean for you? This has implications for how you choose to live your life.

What does it mean for your church? This has implications for how to choose to devote your resources and attention.

What does it mean for God's church at large?

That's the subject of this book. Once we commit ourselves to follow Christ, we seek to know His will for our lives. We seek to understand the Lord's will in the different decisions we encounter and the circumstances of our lives.

For the church or parachurch organizations we join or lead, we seek His will also for those. How do we sense His will?

This book examines the subject of God's will in the Scriptures through a word study on God's will in the New and Old Testaments. We go directly to the source, God's word, so as to not misunderstand what His will is for us. So many today do not understand it.

When is God's will done?

Before getting into the word study, I begin this book with a very common misunderstanding among Christians. We think that just because something happened on earth, it means it was God's will.

This just isn't true. God's will is good (James 1:17-18), and His good will is not always done.

In fact, His will is *most often* not done.

God does not will that the wicked should die, but rather turn from their ways, repent, and live (Ezekial 18:23,32; 33:11). God's will is that all should come to repentance (Matthew 18:14, 2 Peter 3:9). This most often is not the case.

It was also God's will to create the structure of life according to a legal system that included free will for His created beings, allowing for choice between God's will and their own.

As such, God's will is only done when good is done, when right is done, when His word is done. His word defines what is good and right.

Even among Christians, we very often choose not to do His word. We very often choose *not* to do the thing that faith would require (Romans 14:13). This is sin. Sin interferes with God's will being done in our lives and the lives of others.

Just because it happens, this doesn't mean it is God's will. Further, in a world where Satan has authority (among nonbelievers) and ability, not every open door is an opportunity from God. Many of them are not from Him. (For more on this, see [Flipping Strongholds](#).)

We must look to the truth in His word to know His will.

God's will, New Testament

This chapter is a word study on God's will in the New Testament. The words in the New Testament that refer to God's will are *thelēma* (G2307) and *boulomai* (G1014). Scriptures that contain one of these words are underlined.

Christ's earthly ministry

When Jesus taught His disciples to pray to our heavenly Father "Thy kingdom come, thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven" (Matthew 6:10, also Luke 11:2), it was a decree. God's kingdom is His government and His rule. His kingdom consists of the places where His will is done. The condition of heaven is right, or as things were before the fall of man. There is no sin, sickness, pain or death. The Holy Spirit of God came into Jesus and then to the disciples of Christ to bring God's kingdom to earth. Jesus demonstrated the kingdom by overcoming the works of the devil: sin, sickness, pain and death. Legally, Christ and those who have identified with Him are able to do this because of the fullness of salvation in Jesus Christ, brought about by His suffering at the whipping post and His death on the cross. Christ has all authority on heaven, on earth, and under the earth. Christ's authority during His earthly ministry was enabled by the suffering and death He would undergo at the end of His earthly ministry (Matthew 8:16-17). To what extent is God's will being done on earth in and through you?

After Christ's death, His disciples who do God's will cause His kingdom to come to earth, as it is in heaven. The key examples of these disciples in scripture include the Apostle Peter and the Apostle Paul, who, like Jesus, had ministries wherein they healed the sick, cast out demons, and raised the dead. For more on their ministries, see my books *Experiencing Christ through Peter* and *Experiencing Christ in Paul* at www.jason.church. Since Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today and forever (Hebrews 13:8), Christ living in believers is still the same today, limited only by faith and consecration. Have you fully consecrated yourself to God?

Today, believers and churches that welcome the work of the Spirit of God do see it in some measure, again limited in persons by faith and consecration. In churches, there are limits based on the persons that comprise them and based on unity in the body that needs to work together as one. The Spirit of God still works together with disciples and confirms their message as they seek to be obedient to proclaim the gospel and make disciples (Mark 16:20). For these believers, Jesus' statement to His own disciples is still true: "... it is to your advantage that I go away, for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you" (John 16:7). The Spirit of God is now multiplied in His faithful church, the body of Christ, to carry out the function of Jesus Christ in multiplied form throughout the world. Jesus Christ's mission is to cause God's kingdom to come and His will to be done on earth, as it is in heaven. While God's kingdom expands throughout the earth, the devil and his realm of darkness is put under foot, bringing glory to God. How are you teamed together with Christ's functioning body today?

Yet, for those who limit the Spirit's work by unbelief and by way of removing this part of the message, there is no message to confirm. There is no faith to stimulate the Spirit's work. We live

in the time prophesied by the Apostle Paul where people will be lovers of self, “having the appearance of godliness, but denying its power” (2 Timothy 3:1-9). As such, God’s will is most often not done. How is your faith limiting what God has for you?

The heavens are open to those who have Christ abiding in them as Lord over all. Will you be a place where God’s will is done? Is your family such a place? Is your church such a place? For more on Christ’s Lordship, see my book [Rooms](#). This book is a challenge to me as well. For more on working together as one body under the lordship of Christ, see www.teams.church.

Jesus told His own disciples, “Not everyone who says to me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ will enter the kingdom of heaven, but the one who does the will of my Father who is in heaven” ([Matthew 7:21](#)). He meant what He said. Today many call Christ Lord because they know He needs to be Lord in order for them to go to heaven; this has been well taught in church in the era of born again Christianity. Yet, very few do the will of the Father. His will is His word to us, as recorded in Scripture. We are to be doers of God’s word, just as Jesus taught His disciples (Luke 6:46-49, Luke 8:19-21). We are to be doers of God’s word, just as Jesus’ brother James taught the early church at Jerusalem (James 1:21). If we will be saved, we are called to follow Christ, and with following Him comes obedience to His word. The path of repentance to which we are all called is an upward trajectory where our mind becomes remade into the mind of Christ (1 Corinthians 2:16) as we learn to walk as He walked (1 John 2:6), in obedience to all of the will of our Father. How much of God’s word are you obeying?

The children of God are those born of God’s will ([John 1:12-13](#)). They receive and lay hold of Christ, identifying themselves with Him, trusting in His name and authority. About these children, Jesus taught, “For whoever does the will of my Father in heaven is my brother and sister and mother” ([Matthew 12:50](#), also [Mark 3:35](#)). Like Jesus Christ, God’s children allow themselves to be led by the Spirit (Romans 8:14) to do God’s will. During His ministry, Jesus’ food was to do the Father’s will, and finish His work ([John 4:34](#)). Like Jesus, we are to live here as those sent by God, empowered by His Spirit. Like Jesus, we are to learn to do God’s will as a lifestyle, busy about our Father’s business. Those who faithfully choose to do God’s will are co-heirs together with Christ (Romans 8:16-17,29). By what or by whom are you led?

God’s will for all is repentance and obedience to His word ([Matthew 21:28-32](#)). As disciples of Christ, it does not matter what we want to do or feel led to do; it only matters what God has commanded us to do in His word. We are to change our minds to align our will with God’s will revealed in His word. God’s work in this world is to become our work. This is God’s way to have His rule and government established in and through our lives. This is how His will is done on earth as it is in heaven. To what extent has God established His rule in your life?

Since it is not the will of our Father in heaven that any children should perish, God sent Jesus Christ into the world to seek and save the lost, just as a shepherd goes to save one lost sheep ([Matthew 18:10-14](#)). God rejoices over every one that comes to repentance. Each one made in His image is precious to Him. Since God wills everyone to be saved, we are all to obey God’s word to proclaim the gospel and make disciples. We do not know who will respond to the good

news of the gospel, so we should show no partiality. How is your life aligned with God's will to seek and save the lost?

When we come to know God's word, we know His will. When we come to know God's will, we must renew our minds, aligning ourselves with His will, then do it. This is what faithful and wise stewards do; and to whom much is entrusted, much is required. They will be blessed and set over God's household and all He has. Punishment awaits the disobedient (Luke 12:42-48). How do you regularly align yourself with God's will?

The Spirit of God dwelling in Him, Jesus aligned His mind and will with that Spirit, and, therefore, our Father, such that His thoughts were those of our Father rather than His own. This is what allowed Him to hear from our Father. This is what enabled Him to work together with God to bring about His rule and government, making the situation at hand right (John 5:30). This is how He fulfilled God's will to bring life to those who put their trust in Him (John 6:38-40). This path of obedience to God's will is also the only way for us to know the truth (John 7:17) and to know God as Father the way Jesus does (Matthew 11:27, Luke 10:22). It's the only way to cooperate with God such that He hears us and works together with us (John 9:31). Does your posture of surrender allow for the Spirit of God to abide in you?

God's will is good. In all things, whatever His creation may do, His will is to turn the situation into His glory. Because of man's condemnation under His law of sin and death (Romans 8:1-2), God's plan became sacrificing His own Son in order to save a family of His image bearers for Himself. Although it was not Jesus' will to go to His suffering and death, He aligned Himself with God's will and followed through in obedience, drinking from the cup of God's wrath in our place (Matthew 26:42, Luke 22:42). Because of God's great love for us (Ephesians 2:4), those who identify themselves with Jesus Christ have been made righteous (2 Corinthians 5:21). The law of the Spirit of life has set us free from the law of sin and death (Romans 8:2). Will you follow Christ's example to align your will with God's will in all things?

Christ's ministry in Paul

The resurrected Jesus Christ drew the Apostle Paul to Himself in order to teach us what it looked like for His Spirit to live in a man, doing the Father's will on earth. Paul described Himself as an apostle by God's will (1 Corinthians 1:1, 2 Corinthians 1:1, Ephesians 1:1, Colossians 1:1, 2 Timothy 1:1), or one who went about proclaiming the gospel and making disciples while starting and building up churches in order to build God's kingdom on earth. When Ananias acted for God to restore Paul's sight, he told Paul that he had been chosen by God to know His will, see and know the Righteous One, hear God's voice, and be His witness unto all men (Acts 22:12-15).

It is not God's will for all to be apostles. God's word says, "he gave the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, the shepherds and teachers, to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ, until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ, so that we may no longer be children, tossed to and fro by the waves..." (Ephesians 4:11-14). Rather, it is God's will for us all to be ministers that build up the functioning body of Christ in the world which accomplishes His will. Ministers are servants of mankind on behalf of God; they are priests. Priests are servants who are separated unto God. God's will is for our sanctification (holiness) that affects our every action (1 Thessalonians 4:3, Hebrews 10:10).

Further, it is God's will for us to be His children (Ephesians 1:5), and, as children of God (and co-heirs together with Jesus Christ, Romans 8:17) that we reach maturity in our likeness to Jesus Christ, both in character and in deed. This means we must put God's word into practice; for example, as disciples of Christ we are all responsible to proclaim the gospel and make disciples. (For more examples of what it means to put God's word into practice, according to Jesus, see www.teams.church). Some of us will grow up to be those who, after being equipped and putting God's word into practice, go on to fully equip others to do the same, thereby enabling more good works to be done through Jesus Christ (Hebrews 13:20-21). Those who handle responsibility over God's kingdom well will be given more responsibility. It is God's will that we take on responsibility over part of His kingdom. It is His will for us to be kings and priests in His kingdom (Revelation 1:5-6). For more on God's kingdom, see my book [The Gospel of the Kingdom](#). What is your role as a minister? How have you taken responsibility for God's kingdom work in this world?

For the Apostle Paul, God's will for the moment and the day at hand was quite clear. He was to perform His functions of doing God's word and building His church as an apostle. Rather than asking God's will for the moment, He simply did it in cooperation with God, obedient to the thoughts that came to Him from God's Spirit. Shortly after Paul came to faith in Christ, he began preaching the faith he once tried to destroy (Galatians 1:21-24). On his first missionary journey in Cyprus, he cooperated with God to stop the interference of a false prophet (Acts 13:4-12). At Lystra, Paul cooperated with God to heal a man crippled from birth who was listening to him (Acts 14:1-18). For more on the ways Paul, as an example for us, followed God's will in the

moment, see [Experiencing Christ in Paul](#). Are you tuned in to know God's will in the moment? Are you obedient to follow His promptings?

On the other hand, Paul was unsure about what the following days held for Him, particularly whether it was God's will for Him to go visit different churches. For example, Paul prayed to be able to visit the Roman church by God's will ([Romans 1:10](#)). Paul also asked the Romans to pray with him that he might come to them by God's will ([Romans 15:30-32](#)). The Apostle James had a similar stance toward God's will for following days ([James 4:13-16](#)). He instructed believers that they were simply to do what was right and good in God's sight in the moment ([James 4:17](#)). We are to do today what faith would instruct us to do, or it is sin. Do you allow yourself to be led by God's Spirit to make the choices today that are instructed by faith? Or is your focus more on the future?

Paul taught us that when we are instructed in God's word, we will know His will ([Romans 2:17-18](#)). His will is that we do His word. His will is that we become men and women after God's own heart, doing all of His will ([Acts 13:22](#), [Colossians 4:12](#)). Like Christ, it should be our delight to do His will ([Hebrews 10:7-9](#)/[Psalm 40:8](#)). This happens through a process of transformation. We must cooperate with the Spirit of God who lives in us to be transformed by the renewal of our mind to God's word in order to recognize and do God's will ([Romans 12:2](#)). By coming to think like Jesus Christ and act on God's word like Jesus Christ, we take on the mind of Christ that we have been given ([1 Corinthians 2:16](#)). This is the mind of the Spirit of God. Only by taking on this mind may we all "attain to the unity of the faith" ([Ephesians 4:13](#)). It is God's will for us that we be so transformed. To what extent are you still double-minded? To what extent has your mind been renewed to the word of God?

It's God's will that we live as those directly connected to Him ([1 Corinthians 6:17](#)), just as Paul lived. This means we live as those who have been delivered by Christ from this present evil world ([Galatians 1:4](#), [Ephesians 2:1-3](#), [2 Timothy 2:26](#)). Directly connected to Him, it is His will that we pray without ceasing, rejoicing and giving thanks in all things ([1 Thessalonians 5:16-18](#)). When we pray according to His word and will, we can expect Him to answer, rejoicing and giving thanks in advance of seeing the answer come to pass. Directly connected to the Giver, we are to generously give ourselves to God and to the rest of the church ([2 Corinthians 8:1-5](#)). Directly connected to God, we can expect to be filled with the knowledge of God's will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding ([Colossians 1:9](#)). This allows us in all circumstances to live wisely, making the best use of our time, doing God's will with singleness of mind and purpose ([Acts 21:14](#), [Ephesians 5:14-17](#), [6:5-7](#)). After we have done God's will, we are to patiently and steadfastly wait in faith to receive what God has promised us in Christ ([Hebrews 10:36-38](#)), both now through the Holy Spirit and later in the fullness of our inheritance ([Ephesians 1:11-14](#)). Directly connected now to the Spirit of God, God divides His nature, power and gifting into the body of Christ according to God's will ([1 Corinthians 12:11](#)). It is His will that we get up, go out in the world, and use the divine gifts given to us in order to accomplish His will for His glory. In the fullness of time, it is God's will to unite all things in Him, things in heaven and things in earth ([Ephesians 1:9-10](#)). Are you now living as one directly connected to God? (For more on this topic, see [Directly Connected to the Spirit, Mind, and Body of Christ](#).)

Christ's teaching through Peter and John

The Spirit of God accomplished God's will through the ministry of the Apostle Peter and the Apostle John. In particular, Peter, like Paul, ministered in ways similar to Jesus Christ, because Christ lived in him. (For more on this, see [Experiencing Jesus through Peter](#).) The Spirit also prophesied God's word through Peter and John.

It is not God's will that any should perish but that all should come to repentance ([2 Peter 3:9](#)). Further, it is God's will that we should continue on the path of repentance, wherein we cooperate with Him to put off our old self and put on the mind of Christ. This leads us to live to do the will of God ([1 Peter 4:1-2](#)). The Spirit of God leads us to go about doing good and doing what is right, as our Lord Jesus did, giving witness to all men (Acts 10:38, [1 Peter 2:15](#)). As with Jesus, if we require anything according to God's will, He hears us. As with Jesus, this should give us boldness in God ([1 John 5:14](#)). As Christ followers in this ungodly world, it may be God's will that we, like Christ, experience suffering through persecution because of the good we do in Jesus' name ([1 Peter 3:17, 4:19](#)). In any case, we are to do God's will through our obedience to do His word. Only those who do God's will abide forever with Him ([1 John 2:17](#)). We were created to abide now and forever with Him. God created us (and all things) for His purpose, pleasure, and will, so He is worthy to receive all worship, glory, honor, and power, both now and forever ([Revelation 4:10-11](#)). Are you living a life of repentance? How does your lifestyle bring glory to God?

God's will, Old Testament

This chapter is a word study on God's will in the Old Testament. The words in the Old Testament that refer to God's will are châphêts (H2654), chêphets (H2656), and râtsôn (H7522). Scriptures that contain one of these words are underlined.

In the Old Testament, we learn it was God's will to make provision for sinners through Jesus Christ. God does not will that the wicked should die, but rather turn from their ways, repent, and live (Ezekial 18:23,32; 33:11). Our Creator God delights to show mercy and forgive (Micah 7:18). In response, God's son, Jesus Christ, came into the world, delighting to do God's will, God's law written on His heart and mind (Psalms 40:8, Hebrews 10:7-9). God's will was to heal us by His stripes, put our sicknesses and sin upon Him, and crush Him in our place, in order to make us righteous and give us eternal life with Him (Isaiah 53:5-11). Have you believed in the fullness of salvation that is yours in Jesus Christ? Do you speak of it?

It is God's will that we delight in and take on His own character and nature, which has been enabled through Christ's sacrifice. As God's people, we are to confess our sin, separate ourselves from the ungodly world, and do His will (Ezra 10:11). It is God's pleasure that we glory in understanding and knowing Him and His character, wherein He exercises loving kindness, justice and righteousness (Jeremiah 9:24, Hosea 6:6). Further, it is God's will for us to take on His character, exercising loving kindness and justice and leading a righteous lifestyle (Proverbs 11:1,20, Hosea 6:6). To what extent have you taken on God's own character and nature?

It is God's will for His spoken word to be done. God's spoken word will go forth and prosper, accomplishing what He pleases, rather than returning void (Isaiah 55:11). God's word is done by His host of obedient ministers, including both angels and us (Psalms 103:20-21). We are meant to be servants that join the angels in carrying out His will. God delights in our loving obedience to His spoken word (1 Samuel 15:22). We are to cooperate with God both to speak the words He has spoken and do them. How well do you cooperate with God to speak and to do His word?

In this time of God's favor, may we learn to do God's will on earth as it is in heaven. Christ lives in us to do just that. We can expect God's Spirit both to instruct us in God's will and lead us to do it (Psalms 143:10). In His very nature, there is life, strength, and joy (Psalms 30:5-7, Proverbs 8:35). It is His will to do good and to build up (Psalms 51:18). It is His will to meet peoples' needs, set them free, and channel His life to them (Isaiah 58:5-11). It is His will to work with us to bring freedom and to overcome any obstacles that interfere with building His kingdom (Isaiah 49:6-11). His will for us is to proclaim His good news of liberty to all who are captive, open their prison in Christ's name, and, moved with His own compassion, bind up all who are brokenhearted (Isaiah 61:1-2). God delights to lead us to abundant life (Numbers 14:8). Do you see your days as opportunities to join God's work to do His will on earth as it is done in heaven?

Conclusion

Let's not confuse God's will with our own desires, our interpretation of God's word according to those desires, our circumstances or opportunities that seem to be lined up to fulfill our desires, or the encouragement we receive from others for us to pursue what pleases us.

Many try to seek God's will apart from what it is outlined to be in Scripture because they have misunderstood that God is no respecter of persons. He shows no favoritism. Just as the benefits of salvation that He offers to all of us are the same, His general call and His high expectations of all of His children are the same. The main differences among us come in our faith in the goodness of God and His word, the character that we develop, the responsibility we decide to take on, the words we speak, and the things we choose to do with our time, attention and energy.

God's will is His revealed by His word that we are to obey. As Christ's disciples, we are to do *all* of God's will. So let's stop seeking His individual will for each one of our lives and simply start putting His word into practice.

If we can't be obedient to what He already told us to do, why should He give us additional instructions?